

# From Pemberton Street to the Academy of Music: How Franklin Guinn Turned a Childhood of Song into an Historic Concert

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## Growing up In Shiloh Baptist Circa 1845

At the corner of Clifton and South Streets, once the city's edge, a seven-year-old Franklin Guinn helped his church community construct Shiloh Baptist Church in 1845. Brother Sheppard Patterson contributed 500 bricks while women scrubbed and men laid them; Franklin hauled trash.

Shiloh began around 1842 as a small offshoot of First African Baptist, initially meeting in a wooden structure behind Absalom Jones's home at 409 South 11th Street. Franklin's father Peter was there from the beginning. When the church lacked a pastor, Reverend Jeremiah Durham from nearby Barley Street preached.

Franklin remembered his mother singing "Roll On Silver Moon" while playing guitar during early programs. He also recalled being frightened of certain church women, particularly Aunt Jane Brooker and "Bud Jack."

Growing up on Temperance Street (now Pemberton), just above Fitzwater, Franklin spent considerable time in the neighborhood. He fondly recalled geese, chickens, and pigs roaming Clifton and Kater streets, and described an old junk shop at Clifton and South as "the greatest place on earth."

The 1847 Census confirmed his residence on Temperance Place. He attended school at the Lombard Street location (6th and Lombard), likely alongside Octavius Catto and Jacob C. White Jr., both future civil rights leaders.

His household included two formerly enslaved people who had purchased their own freedom for \$150—most likely his parents.

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## And then....Music!

Elizabeth Taylor Greenfield, known as the "Black Swan," arrived at Shiloh to teach music. She wasn't simply instructing solos or hymns; she was building something larger. Franklin became one of her students.

By age 14, Franklin likely attended Shiloh's 1852 public science lecture featuring an "Oxygen Microscope" exhibition—advertised as "Wonders of the Microscopic World"—with proceeds benefiting the church.

Shiloh demonstrated progressive values. In 1855, Black women from Shiloh led organizing efforts supporting Mary Ann Shad Cary's influential visit to Philadelphia.

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## War and Family

Franklin enlisted with the Colored Troops and served in the U.S. Navy during the Civil War aboard the USS Princeton. Military records show he was five foot four.

He married during the early 1860s, though his first wife died in Liberia. Upon returning, he married Anna. Their family faced tragedies: daughter Gertrude died of pleurisy at age two, prepared for burial by Henriette Duterte, America's first female undertaker. Son John Edward died of cholera at thirteen months.

By 1880, Franklin relocated to 1125 Lombard Street, directly across from the new Shiloh building. His daughter Anna was twelve, and he and wife Anna had another infant.

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## Rise of the Shiloh Musical Association

Franklin's musical interests resurfaced. As musical director, he arranged for an orchestra during Shiloh's 1883 Easter service, prompting church deacons to object—they debated whether horns belonged in church and agreed to prohibit them that Sunday.

That October, Franklin attended a choral concert at the Academy of Music. Due to segregation, he sat in the amphitheater's top section.

An ambitious vision crystallized: a massive concert featuring 300 singers, an orchestra, and an organ—at the Academy of Music, for Shiloh.

Church leadership eventually approved, though many considered the plan foolish and destined to fail. Singers from Philadelphia and Boston signed up for what would become an enormous choir.

Then, in November 1883, Franklin's wife Anna died in a tragic accident. The incident appears unmentioned in his later book, leaving his emotional state during planning unclear.

Despite detractors—including the white press calling him a "Foolhardy Negro"—Franklin persisted: "we just simply kept on engaging, practicing and posting bills."

## The Historic Concert

On February 5, 1884, the concert materialized at the Academy of Music with an 18-piece orchestra, 300-person choir, and organ. The response was tremendous—a packed house loved the performance. The Philadelphia Times wrote, "The singers all gave evidence of careful training and the concert reflected much credit up Frank A. Guinn, the conductor."

The concert raised \$984 (approximately \$30,000 today) after expenses, funding Shiloh's relocation to the new building across from Franklin's home.

The Shiloh Musical Association gained prominence, becoming actively sought for performances. John Wanamaker admired them so greatly he called them "his choir."

## Significance and Legacy

The 1884 Academy of Music concert proved historic. Only a decade earlier, Frederick Douglass refused to speak there, protesting racist policies. Though the Academy eventually admitted Black people by 1883, Guinn was relegated to amphitheater seating—the "Peanut Gallery." His decision to fill that prestigious venue with 300 singers represented a remarkable assertion.

Both original and second Shiloh buildings remain standing. The current congregation worships in a newer building on Christian Street.

Franklin Guinn died in 1912 and was buried at Philadelphia National Cemetery, West Oak Lane, under a veterans headstone. He left behind a remarkable legacy: a boy enchanted by a junk shop, a frightened church child, a teenage science enthusiast, Elizabeth Taylor Greenfield's student, and ultimately a man whose choir built a church.

### Reflection Questions

- How might Elizabeth Taylor Greenfield have reacted to the Academy of Music concert?
- Why did Franklin Guinn select the Academy of Music specifically?
- What characterized daily life for young men like Guinn, Catto, and White during 1840s-1850s Philadelphia?
- What aspects of this church family's history surprise contemporary readers?

### Images

- AI image of Franklin A. Guinn, outside of Shiloh Baptist in the 1870s — [https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d\\_952122f99eb7468291b7d891590f3230~mv2.png](https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_952122f99eb7468291b7d891590f3230~mv2.png)
- Corner of Clifton and South, Courtesy Google Maps — [https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d\\_e0364a2a6cbc4d799102ae713d078366~mv2.png](https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_e0364a2a6cbc4d799102ae713d078366~mv2.png)
- Shiloh Baptist Church video — [https://video.wixstatic.com/video/af048d\\_240a4df727bc4a02baf683014c204038/1080p/mp4/file.mp4](https://video.wixstatic.com/video/af048d_240a4df727bc4a02baf683014c204038/1080p/mp4/file.mp4)
- AI image of Franklin Guinn and his mother at church in 1845 — [https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d\\_d7158d5fe05c42a78f1a494e04614db1~mv2.png](https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_d7158d5fe05c42a78f1a494e04614db1~mv2.png)
- Excerpt from The Rise and Progress of Shiloh Baptist, Page 72 — [https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d\\_b5e76db4ae0643cbb35fa601919a5016~mv2.png](https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_b5e76db4ae0643cbb35fa601919a5016~mv2.png)
- AI Image of 8 year old Franklin Guinn at junk shop, 1847 — [https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d\\_24b79e8049094472b53a8b4b4c57db21~mv2.png](https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_24b79e8049094472b53a8b4b4c57db21~mv2.png)
- Peter Guinn on Temperance Place from the 1847 PAS Census — [https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d\\_7f47592186ca41d096f8d4d9360104cd~mv2.png](https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_7f47592186ca41d096f8d4d9360104cd~mv2.png)
- Map showing distance from Temperance Place to Shiloh — [https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d\\_dcc3580a89ba45eda34337aa223d1c1a~mv2.png](https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_dcc3580a89ba45eda34337aa223d1c1a~mv2.png)
- The street Franklin Guinn grew up on, Pemberton between S. Schell and S. Mildred — [https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d\\_5eca9ebdfcf741cebfd2d9bcace8fde6~mv2.jpeg](https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_5eca9ebdfcf741cebfd2d9bcace8fde6~mv2.jpeg)
- Elizabeth Taylor Greenfield - 'The Black Swan' — [https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d\\_74913a9116c14dceb3847f8d17292e65~mv2.jpg](https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_74913a9116c14dceb3847f8d17292e65~mv2.jpg)
- Excerpt from The Rise and Progress of Shiloh Baptist, music instruction page 277 — [https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d\\_39a5364bbf984ed8a28778e0a9577ea5~mv2.png](https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_39a5364bbf984ed8a28778e0a9577ea5~mv2.png)
- Ad from the Public Ledger, 11/9/1852 — [https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d\\_c84cae269c47403393398816822fb7b9~mv2.png](https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_c84cae269c47403393398816822fb7b9~mv2.png)
- AI image of 14 year old Franklin Guinn with microscope, 1852 — [https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d\\_fb109f4ad2c84588bd9fab71b351cc25~mv2.jpg](https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_fb109f4ad2c84588bd9fab71b351cc25~mv2.jpg)
- Excerpt from The Rise and Progress of Shiloh Baptist, page 295 — [https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d\\_45fdbb7472c041fe885ebf35aee16562~mv2.png](https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_45fdbb7472c041fe885ebf35aee16562~mv2.png)
- The Academy of Music Philadelphia —

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- The Philadelphia Times, 11/23/1883 —  
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  - Excerpt from The Rise and Progress of Shiloh Baptist Church, page 296 —  
[https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d\\_a2dd61681eb040b38db880c8cfff471~mv2.png](https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_a2dd61681eb040b38db880c8cfff471~mv2.png)
  - AI image of the February 5, 1884 Shiloh Musical Association Concert —  
[https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d\\_84f389511a29420199dfbb6e52e1d169~mv2.png](https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_84f389511a29420199dfbb6e52e1d169~mv2.png)
  - Review from The Philadelphia Times, February 6, 1884 —  
[https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d\\_1785c87a9f3c4c64afc990b8a81500ed~mv2.png](https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_1785c87a9f3c4c64afc990b8a81500ed~mv2.png)
  - Excerpt from The Rise and Progress of Shiloh Baptist Church, page 294 —  
[https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d\\_897be95732f94d209833fe698abae669~mv2.png](https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_897be95732f94d209833fe698abae669~mv2.png)
  - Franklin Guinn, from William Carl Bolivar's Philadelphia Tribune column, 9/28/1912 —  
[https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d\\_a840134de9c740b4b72797c7bb6c68d2~mv2.png](https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_a840134de9c740b4b72797c7bb6c68d2~mv2.png)
  - Headstone of Franklin A. Guinn at Philadelphia National Cemetery —  
[https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d\\_81f5b023561246cea95ed405f09f9c78~mv2.png](https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_81f5b023561246cea95ed405f09f9c78~mv2.png)

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